syngenta

Agriculture on Mars | START HACK 2026

NASA's planned missions to Mars in the late 2030s raise a critical challenge: how to grow nutritionally balanced food for astronauts during long-duration space travel and extended surface stays. Participants are asked to design an autonomous AI agent system that manages a Martian greenhouse and demonstrates its capabilities through a working simulation or digital twin. The solution should optimize nutrient output, dietary balance, and resource efficiency for a crew of four astronauts, while also offering insights that could benefit autonomous agriculture in extreme environments on Earth.

BELIMO®

Smart Actuators | START HACK 2026

Belimo's field devices generate valuable operational data, but this data is currently not being used to create additional customer value. The challenge is to develop innovative concepts that analyze actuator signals such as torque, motor position, and temperature to generate actionable insights for installation, commissioning, and operation. These insights should help improve efficiency, detect malfunctions, reduce costs, and create measurable value for customers in commercial building HVAC systems.

A range of Belimo products will be available on site for interactive use. Participants can engage directly with the devices, generate data and measurements, and observe the outcomes.

Zwick / Roell

AI-Powered Data Analytics | START HACK 2026

Modern materials testing produces vast amounts of valuable data, but extracting insights from large test cohorts is still slow and difficult — in many labs, data analysis still feels like it's stuck in 1995. Materials and quality engineers have the domain expertise to ask the right questions, yet often lack the tools and data science background to explore complex and inhomogeneous datasets effectively. Your challenge is to build a working AI-powered analytics assistant that allows engineers to interact with lab testing data through natural language. The system should generate data-driven insights and explain its reasoning transparently, supported by visualizations where helpful.

The goal is not perfect analysis, but a functional prototype that demonstrates a new way for engineers to interact with industrial data.

Smart Data Mapping | START HACK 2026

Healthcare data originates from multiple heterogeneous systems – hospital information systems, laboratory software, Excel exports, and even free text reports. These sources vary widely in format, semantics, and data quality. Current harmonization and processing require numerous manual steps, leading to inefficiency and limited scalability.

Objective: Develop an intelligent application that automates data mapping across all formats and sources. Whether dealing with structured tables, PDFs, or unstructured text, the solution should autonomously identify, align, and transform data into a unified target model.

PostFinance

Investment Education | START HACK 2026

Too many adults never start investing even though long-term investing is one of the most important paths to building wealth. The challenge is to create “Wealth Manager Arena: The Investing Game (Bull vs Bear Edition)”: a playable, gamified investment education prototype that helps beginners learn core principles (risk profiling, diversification, long-term thinking, asset classes, and handling volatility) without risking real money.

Your goal is to make investing feel safe to try, engaging to learn, and realistic enough to correct common misconceptions (e.g., investing = short-term gambling).

studyond

OST
Eastern Switzerland
University of Applied Sciences

AI Thesis Copilot | START HACK 2026

Every year, thousands of students start their thesis facing the same fragmented experience searching university websites for supervisors, browsing company career pages for industry topics, and cold-messaging professionals for expert interviews. The information exists - but it's scattered, unstructured, and hard to navigate. Students waste weeks on logistics instead of research.

Studyond already has all the building blocks: thousands of thesis topics from hundreds of companies, supervisors, industry experts, 20+ universities, and an AI matching engine - all connected, all live. What's missing is the intelligent experience layer that weaves it all together into a guided, AI-native thesis journey. The winning solution could directly shape our product roadmap.

#AcceleratingWhatsNext

CHAINIQ SIMPLY SMART

Sourcing Agent | START HACK 2026

Large enterprises receive purchase requests that are often incomplete, inconsistent, or urgent yet procurement teams still need to make fast, policy-compliant decisions they can defend in audits. In this hackathon, you'll build a working prototype that turns an unstructured request into structured requirements, applies procurement rules, compares suppliers, and explains why a recommendation is compliant (or flags when it isn't). Your solution should handle both a standard request and an edge case, including clear escalation logic when a confident automated decision can't be made.